

Abortion Should Be Legal In All States

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Opinion Brief

Approximately ninety-eight percent of women, ranging from ages fifteen to forty-four, do not have access to abortion. As of 2025, around 62.7 million women live in states with an abortion ban. Ever since *Roe v. Wade* was overturned, the right to have an abortion has been under the control of the state governments. Over 20 states have extremely strict laws or have completely banned abortion altogether. This leads to the question that is most frequently asked: Should abortion be legal in all states? To answer that, abortion should be legal in all states because it is a basic human right and it results in unsafe practices.

First of all, abortion should be legal nationwide because it is a basic human right. Everyone deserves the right to make choices regarding their own body, so why does abortion not count as part of that right? The government is not entitled to enforce laws that prevent people from making personal decisions.

The Human Rights Watch states, “Countries have obligations to respect, protect, and fulfill human rights, including those concerning sexual and reproductive health and autonomy. Where safe and legal abortion services are unreasonably restricted or not fully available, many other internationally protected human rights may be at risk, including rights to nondiscrimination and equality; to life, health, and information; to freedom from torture and cruel, inhuman and degrading treatment; to privacy and bodily autonomy and integrity; to decide the number and spacing of children; to liberty; to enjoy the benefits of scientific progress; and to freedom of conscience and religion” (Access to Abortion is a Human Right 2).

This excerpt shows that reproductive liberty is not just one issue, but rather a significant factor in overall human freedom. When state governments restrict these protections, they compromise an individual’s rights to safety, equality, and privacy.

In addition, Amnesty International also states, “International human rights law clearly spells out that decisions about your body are yours alone – this is what is known as bodily autonomy. The right to make autonomous decisions about one’s reproductive life is known as reproductive autonomy. Forcing someone to carry on an unwanted pregnancy, or forcing them to seek out an unsafe abortion, is a violation of their human rights, including the rights to privacy and bodily and reproductive autonomy” (Abortion Rights 6).

This quote highlights that reproductive liberty is not merely a political debate, but a fundamental component of international law regarding individual freedom. When state governments restrict these protections, they effectively strip people of the right to self-government.

Likewise, people often resort to choices when their freedom is limited. This is why many women are performing unsafe abortions because they do not have the resources to have a medical professional do it for them. This is because the medical procedure itself is expensive,

and out-of-state travel adds to the total cost, leading people to take matters into their own hands. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), “Many physical risks incomplete abortion (failure to remove or expel all pregnancy tissue from the uterus), haemorrhage (heavy bleeding), infection, uterine perforation (caused when the uterus is pierced by a sharp object), and damage to the genital tract and internal organs as a consequence of inserting dangerous objects into the vagina or anus” (WHO “Abortion” 14).

This excerpt shows how unsafe it is to have a self-induced abortion, especially if you do not have medical training. Not only does an unsafe abortion lead to long-term side effects, it could also lead to death. Individuals are often forced to choose between dangerous methods and their own reproductive futures when legal access is restricted. This harsh reality displays that banning the procedure does not stop the need for it, but rather shifts the care away from medical professionals into unsafe environments.

Beyond physical health, unsafe abortions have effects on emotional well-being. These effects include PTSD, substance abuse, self-harm, anxiety, depression, severe isolation, grief, and guilt. While many may argue that they could go to another state and have it done there, it is important to recognize that going to another state to have an abortion is significantly more expensive. Ultimately, unsafe abortions are one of the many consequences of limiting one’s choice to abort.

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